A third of our customers are loyal, half have gone quiet, and sales surge every autumn

We looked at 5,852 customers and about £19M of sales over two years (Dec 2009 to Nov 2011). The questions: who are our customers, who are we losing, and when should we prepare?

WHO

Half of all customers have not bought for a long time. Only a third are loyal buyers.

Loyal 2,068 customers

35%

Buy often, recently, and spend the most

Dormant 2,925 customers

50%

Last bought long ago, low spend

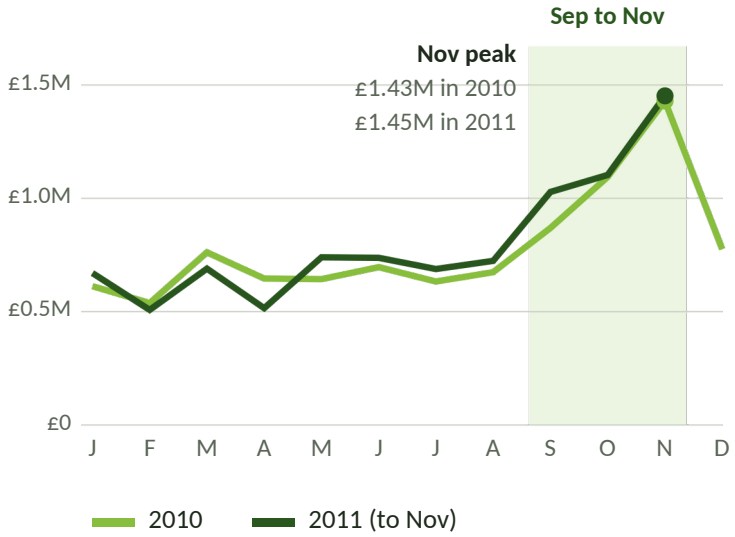
New 859 customers

15%

First purchase wasrecent

WHEN

Sales peak in November, at about double a normal month. The peak was the same in 2010 and 2011.



Sep to Nov brings about 37% of a year's sales. A typical order is over 100 items, so buyers look like businesses stocking up.

WHERE AND WHAT

Most sales are in the UK, and a few products sell well all year.

Share of sales

UK 85.5% | 14.5%

International: 9% of customers, mostly Germany and France

Always in the top sellers, every season

- White hanging heart T-light holder
- Jumbo bag red retrospot
- Pack of 72 retro spot cake cases
- World War 2 gliders (assorted)
- Assorted colour bird ornament

These items sell in every season, so they should never run out.

What to do: win back the quiet half, protect the loyal third, and stock up before September

Groups	WHAT WE DO	WHY IT MATTERS
Loyal 2,068 customers, 35%	Give them a dedicated contact, early access to the autumn range, and volume pricing.	Protects our most active buyers and makes their autumn orders easier to plan.
Dormant 2,925 customers, 50%	Send a win-back offer in late August, built around the all-year bestsellers.	The biggest pool of customers. Even a small return costs less than finding new buyers.
New 859 customers, 15%	Follow up before a second order is due, with a reorder offer and a starter bundle.	Turns one-time buyers into repeat buyers, and slows the growth of the lapsed group.
Everyone All customers	Order seasonal stock ahead of September. Keep the bestsellers always in stock.	Avoids stock-outs in Sep to Nov, the months that bring about 37% of yearly sales.

Strengths

- Simple and easy to explain
- Based on real buying behaviour
- Returns are netted out of sales

Limits

- One UK wholesaler, 2009 to 2011
- No cost data, so revenue is not profit
- About 23% of rows have no customer ID

Next steps

- Test the groups on later data
- Predict who is about to leave
- Forecast demand for the autumn peak

Benefits are expected directions, not forecasts. Generative AI use: used to direct, review code and suggest checks. All code was run and every number verified by the author.